CONCRETE BOWL CANDLE HOLDERS

Step-by-Step DIY Guide

Cast Beautiful Concrete Bowls & Fill Them with Your Own Hand-Poured Candles

Four hand-cast concrete bowl candles glowing with warm candlelight

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About This Project

This project combines two crafts into one stunning result: concrete casting and candle making. You'll cast smooth, minimalist concrete bowls using a silicone mold, then fill them with hand-poured soy or paraffin wax and a wick to create beautiful candles that sit inside their own concrete holders. The result is a designer-quality home decor piece that makes a perfect gift — and costs a fraction of what you'd pay in a boutique.

Difficulty	Easy
Yield	4 candle bowls per mold (using the 4-cavity mold shown)
Active time	45–60 minutes (plus curing time)
Concrete cure	24 hours minimum before demolding
Cost per candle	$3–6 USD (candle bowl + wax)
Best for	Home decor, gifts, markets, Etsy shops

Materials & Tools

Part 1 — For the Concrete Bowls

#	Item	Notes
1	Silicone bowl mold (4-cavity)	A purpose-made concrete bowl mold with 4 round bowl cavities and small inner inser
2	Craft concrete mix	Fine-grain concrete or GFRC (glass fiber reinforced concrete) mix. Avoid coarse mix
3	Water	Clean tap water. Mix ratio is approx. 2.5 parts concrete : 1 part water by volume.
4	Mixing bucket + stirrer	A small plastic bucket and an old spoon or silicone spatula.
5	Nitrile gloves	Essential for skin protection against alkaline concrete.
6	Sandpaper (150–220 grit)	For smoothing the rim and any rough edges after demolding.
7	Concrete sealer (optional)	Apply to the inside of the bowl to seal it before adding wax.

Part 2 — For the Candles

#	Item	Notes
1	Soy wax flakes (or paraffin)	Soy wax is natural, burns cleaner, and has excellent scent throw. Use container/pillar
2	Cotton candle wicks (pre-tabbed)	Pre-tabbed wicks with a metal base sit flat on the bowl bottom. Choose wick size bas
3	Fragrance oil or essential oil	10% fragrance load by weight is standard. Lavender, vanilla, sandalwood, and citrus
4	Candle dye (optional)	Liquid or block candle dye for coloured wax. The warm orange tones in the photos ar
5	Pouring jug or pitcher	A heat-safe jug for melting and pouring wax. A dedicated pouring pot is ideal.
6	Double boiler or microwave	To melt wax safely. Never melt wax directly on an open flame or at too-high heat.
7	Thermometer	Candle thermometer — add fragrance at 65–70°C; pour at 55–60°C for soy wax.
8	Wick holders / clothespins	To keep wicks centred while the wax cools and sets.

PART 1 — Cast the Concrete Bowls

Step 1 — Mix the Concrete

In your mixing bucket, combine the craft concrete mix with water. The ratio is approximately **2.5 parts dry concrete mix to 1 part water** by volume. Mix thoroughly for 2–3 minutes until completely smooth — no lumps, no dry powder. The consistency should be like thick yoghurt: pourable but not watery.

- Add water gradually — start with less and add more as needed.
- Mix until the concrete flows smoothly when the bucket is tilted.
- Tap the bucket on the table a few times to release any large air bubbles.

> ■ ***Tip:*** *A drop of dish soap added to the water can help reduce surface bubbles, giving you a smoother finished bowl.*

Step 2 — Pour Concrete into the Mold

Pouring concrete mix into the 4-cavity silicone mold — each cavity has a small inner insert

Filling all four cavities evenly — the inner inserts create the hollow center of each bowl

Place your silicone mold on a flat, level surface. Make sure the small inner plastic inserts are seated in the centre of each cavity — these create the hollow space for the candle wax. Pour the concrete slowly into each cavity, filling evenly around the inner insert.

- Pour slowly and evenly around the insert — don't displace it with a fast pour.
- Fill each cavity to the same level for uniform bowls.
- Tap the mold firmly on the table 10–15 times to release air bubbles.
- Use a toothpick or skewer to pop any surface bubbles you can see.
- If the inner insert floats up, press it back down and let the concrete firm for a few minutes.

■ ***Tip:*** *Slightly overfill each cavity, then scrape level with a flat edge (a ruler or spatula) for a perfectly flat base on each bowl.*

Step 3 — Cure for 24 Hours

Leave the filled mold undisturbed for a minimum of **24 hours** at room temperature. Cover loosely with plastic wrap to slow the cure and prevent surface cracking. The concrete will feel solid to the touch after about 8 hours, but it needs the full 24 hours to develop enough strength for safe demolding.

- Keep the mold on a flat surface — any tilt will create uneven bowls.
- Avoid moving or touching the mold during curing.
- Room temperature 18–25°C is ideal. Avoid cold or freezing conditions.

> ■ ***Tip:*** *In dry conditions, lightly mist the surface with water after 4–6 hours to slow curing and reduce surface cracking.*

Step 4 — Demold the Bowls

Gently peeling the silicone mold away — the concrete bowls release cleanly

After 24 hours, it's time for the reveal! Flex the silicone mold gently from all sides to loosen the bowls, then peel it back carefully. The inner plastic inserts should pull out easily. Your concrete bowls should pop out clean with smooth outer walls.

- Flex the mold inward from the sides before pulling — this breaks the seal.
- Remove the inner insert first by twisting and pulling upward.
- Then invert the mold and press gently to push each bowl out.
- Handle the bowls carefully — concrete continues to harden for up to 28 days.

■ ***Tip:*** *If a bowl seems stuck, wait another 6–12 hours. Forced demolding too early is the most common cause of cracked bowls.*

Step 5 — Sand & Finish the Bowls

Sanding the rim of each bowl smooth with fine-grit sandpaper — the final finishing touch

Once demolded, inspect each bowl. The rim may have a slightly rough or sharp edge from where the concrete was poured. Sand this smooth with 150-grit sandpaper, finishing with 220-grit for a silky feel. Wipe clean with a damp cloth.

- Sand in circular motions on the rim — this is where fingers will touch the most.
- Wet-sanding (dipping the sandpaper in water) gives a smoother result and less dust.
- Optional: apply one coat of concrete sealer to the inside of the bowl — this prevents wax absorption.
- Allow any sealer to fully dry (2–4 hours) before adding wax.

PART 2 — Pour the Candles

Step 6 — Prepare Wicks & Melt the Wax

Place a pre-tabbed wick in the centre of each concrete bowl, pressing the metal tab firmly to the bottom. Use a drop of hot glue to secure it if needed. Meanwhile, melt your soy wax flakes using a double boiler or microwave (in 30-second bursts, stirring between each). Monitor the temperature carefully.

- Melt wax to 75–80°C — hot enough to fully melt but not overheat.
- Add your fragrance oil when wax reaches 65–70°C — stir gently for 2 minutes to fully incorporate.
- Add any candle dye at this stage too — stir until completely dissolved.
- Let the wax cool to 55–60°C before pouring into the concrete bowls.
- Use a wick holder (or two clothespins balanced across the bowl rim) to keep the wick centred.

■ ***Safety:*** *Never leave melting wax unattended. Keep a lid nearby to smother any flame. Never use water to extinguish a wax fire.*

Step 7 — Pour the Wax

Pouring warm soy wax around the centred wick — filling each concrete bowl smoothly

Once the wax has cooled to 55–60°C, carefully pour it into each concrete bowl, pouring around the wick (not directly onto it). Fill to about 5 mm below the rim — this leaves space for any wax top-up needed after the first pour sinks.

- Pour slowly and steadily — avoid splashing.

- Leave 5 mm of wick exposed above the wax surface.
- Do NOT move the bowls while the wax is liquid — any movement creates ripples and an uneven surface.
- After 2 hours, the wax will sink in the centre as it cools — this is normal.
- Do a small second pour at the same temperature to top up the sink hole if needed.

■ ***Tip:*** *For the warmest orange glow shown in the photos, use a small amount of orange candle dye combined with a honey or amber fragrance oil. The concrete bowl amplifies the warm tones beautifully.*

Step 8 — Cure & Trim

Allow the candles to set undisturbed for at least **24 hours** at room temperature before burning. Once set, trim the wick to 6 mm above the wax surface. Your concrete bowl candles are ready!

- Always trim the wick to 6 mm before the first burn and every subsequent burn.
- Allow a full melt pool (wax liquid all the way to the edges) on the first burn — usually 2–3 hours.
- This 'memory burn' prevents tunnelling and ensures even burning on future burns.
- Never burn for more than 4 hours at a time.

The Finished Candles

All four concrete bowl candles glowing — warm, handmade, and completely unique

Pro Tips & Variations

★ **Use GFRC for ultra-smooth bowls**	Glass Fiber Reinforced Concrete (GFRC) mix produces much smoother, lighter, and stronger bowls than standard concrete. It's worth the slightly higher cost for gift-quality pieces.
★ **Add pigment to the concrete**	Charcoal concrete pigment gives a dramatic dark grey look. White pigment creates a minimalist Scandinavian aesthetic. The bowls look completely different depending on the concrete colour.
★ **Layer different wax colours**	Pour a first layer of one colour, let it set partially, then pour a second contrasting colour on top for a beautiful two-tone marbled effect.
★ **Create a matching concrete tray**	Cast the same concrete mix in a flat rectangular mold to create a tray that holds all four bowls — just like the wooden tray shown in the video. It makes the set look incredibly cohesive as a gift.
★ **Scent pairings that work beautifully**	Concrete's natural grey tone pairs best with earthy scents: sandalwood, cedarwood, patchouli, and amber. For a fresh contrast, try eucalyptus or sea salt.
★ **Sell as a gift set**	Four concrete candle bowls on a tray in a kraft paper box with a ribbon makes an outstanding gift set. At craft fairs, sets like this typically retail for $40–70 USD.
★ **Reuse the concrete bowl**	Once the candle is burned down, pour boiling water into the bowl — the remaining wax melts and floats to the top. Pour it out, wipe clean, and add a new candle pour. The concrete bowl lasts indefinitely.
★ **Cold-pour technique for fewer bubbles**	For the smoothest concrete surface, try a slightly drier mix and vibrate the mold by tapping rapidly on the table for 60 seconds after pouring. This brings all bubbles to the surface before the concrete sets.

Troubleshooting

✗ Problem: Bowls have a pitted or bumpy surface

✓ **Solution:** Air bubbles in the concrete mix. Tap the mold more vigorously after pouring (30–60 seconds of tapping). Adding a small drop of dish soap to the mix water also helps.

✗ Problem: The inner insert sank or shifted during curing

✓ **Solution:** The concrete was too wet and the insert floated. Use a slightly stiffer mix next time. You can also weigh the insert down with a small stone or coin during the first hour.

✗ Problem: Bowl cracked during demolding

✓ **Solution:** Demolded too early — wait the full 24 hours. Also check the concrete wasn't too wet. Small cracks can be filled with a slurry of cement and water, let dry, then sand.

✗ Problem: Wax is pulling away from the bowl walls (adhesion shrinkage)

✓ **Solution:** Completely normal with container soy wax — it shrinks slightly as it cools. This is cosmetic only. Try warming the concrete bowl slightly before pouring to reduce the temperature differential.

✗ Problem: Wax surface is bumpy or frosted

✓ **Solution:** Frosting is a natural property of soy wax — it's not a defect. Pour at a lower temperature (55°C) and avoid moving during cooling. A heat gun passed briefly over the surface smooths it.

✗ Problem: Wick is off-centre

✓ **Solution:** The wick wasn't held in place during pouring. Use a wick holder or tape two pencils/chopsticks across the bowl rim to keep the wick perfectly centred while the wax sets.

Thank you for your purchase!

Light one up tonight and enjoy something you made completely by hand. There's nothing quite like that feeling.

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